

The Multiplicity of Meaning, chapter 2

CIAN DORR

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1 *Is the view too friendly to non-disquotational speech reports?*

If Anna uttered ‘The number of guests was much less than 100’, it’s maybe a bit odd to say ‘Anna said that the number of guests was less than n ’ for any $n < 100$. This may seem surprising given pluralism. Shouldn’t I be able to know that for certain n , among the things Anna said was that the number of guests was less than n ?

Not obviously: pluralism is neutral about how often it happens that a single proposition is expressed by two distinct English sentences.

My favoured response to this sort of worry will appeal to the kind of ‘guise-sensitivity’ that makes ‘Anna said that Hesperus is bright’ odd when Anna uttered ‘Phosphorus is bright’, or ‘Anna said that she saw a female fox’ odd when Anna uttered ‘I saw a vixen’.

2 *My defence of the classical approach to the Sorites (reprise)*

INDUCTION Every tolerant property of zero is universal (premise).

CONTRAPOSED INDUCTION So, every non-universal property of zero is not tolerant (from INDUCTION).

INTOLERANCE Every property that is not tolerant is bounded (premise).

BOUNDEDNESS So, every property of zero that is not universal is bounded (from CONTRAPOSED INDUCTION and INTOLERANCE).

3 *Setting aside a bad argument*

Argument Three: When y is one of many entities that are all extremely similar to one another, both in themselves and in their relations to a certain person x , then it would require extraordinary powers of discrimination for x to bear *any* ordinary relation to y without bearing that relation to any of the other entities that are very similar to y . Semantic relations behave in this respect just like all other ordinary relations.

Lots of perfectly ordinary relations don’t work like this—e.g. *advising* doesn’t, since it only holds between people, and each person is coin-

cident or near-coincident with many non-people who are very similar in their relations to any any other person.

The “problem of the many” (Unger 1980) is based on the idea that it is somehow absurd to only one member of some collection of very similar, near-coincident objects is a person/cat/cloud/.... But is nothing *more* absurd about this than there is in the idea that a bald and a non-bald person could differ by a hair.

4 “Explaining away” our aversion to boundedness

The diagnostic project: explain why we are so resistant to instances of Boundedness, given that they are true. Hope: a good explanation of this will diminish our resistance.

Proposal: the resistance rests implicitly on (false) assumptions of monism for some familiar intentional relations, in a way that can be made explicit by the following argument.

UNSHARPNESS No number with every property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’ is such that its successor has *no* property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’.

MEANING ‘Much smaller than 100’ expresses *being much smaller than 100*.

UNIQUENESS ‘Much smaller than 100’ expresses at most one property.

UNBOUNDEDNESS No number that is much smaller than 100 is such that its successor is not much smaller than 100.

We (implicitly) believe UNSHARPNESS because we are sensitive to the “vagueness-conducive” way in which ‘much smaller than 100’ is used, from which it follows.

- Of course, the idea can’t be that we are implicitly aware to the same extent of *every* truth about the meaning-theoretic upshots of these use facts. For example, the use facts in fact secure that ‘much smaller than 100’ expresses multiple properties, but we are not gripped by an inclination to think that it both does and does not express multiple properties.¹

On this picture, although the Sorites is not *about* language, its standard classification as part of the philosophy of language is correct since its grip rests implicitly on thoughts about language. Many explanations of the paradox bring this linguistic element to surface.

¹ Thus, our sensitivity to the truth of UNSHARPNESS does not predict that when *x* has a middling number of hairs and *y* has a middling number of dollars, it will strike us as obviously false that *x* has every property expressed by ‘bald’ and *y* has no property expressed by ‘rich’.

Worry: The sentence UNSHARPNESS doesn't *sound* very natural or gripping. *Reply:* that's because its verbal formulation gives rise to the 'anti-presupposition' inference that ?? is false.

Worry: there is no more basis for attributing our resistance to UNSHARPNESS than to any of the following, which can be substituted without disrupting the validity of the argument, and sound just as good:

UNSHARPNESS^{∀∀} No number with every property expressed by 'much smaller than 100' is such that its successor does not have every property expressed by 'much smaller than 100'.

UNSHARPNESS^{∃∃} No number with some property expressed by 'much smaller than 100' is such that its successor has no property expressed by 'much smaller than 100'.

UNSHARPNESS^{∃∀} No number with some property expressed by 'much smaller than 100' is such that its successor has every property expressed by 'much smaller than 100'.

Reply: these are false, so their appeal just pushes back the need for explanation; we're looking for an explanation that taps into some (partial) sensitivity to the *truth*.

Challenge: Why do we slip into assuming ??, given that it's false?

Reply: some combination of (a) simple wrong turns taken in the history of philosophy; (b) sliding between the count noun and mass noun uses of words like 'meaning'; (c) lack of sensitivity to the fact that ordinary 'I only said one thing' speeches involve restricted quantifier domains.

5 Comparison with other explanations

What about a structurally parallel explanation but substituting some term of art like 'is an admissible interpretation of' for 'is expressed by'?² *Problem:* (a) appeal to such theoretical posits isn't plausible as an explanation of a temptation that even neophytes feel; (b) attributing to neophytes an implicit assumption of ?? for the theoretical posit is extra-implausible, given that the failure of ?? in cases of vagueness is central to its 'theoretical role'.

A similar issue arises for explanations that invoke some non-metalinguistic, non-epistemic 'definitely' operator. It's central to the theoretical role of the operator that it's non-redundant in this sort of context, so if people are implicitly treating some operator as redundant, it seems perverse to interpret them as thinking about *this* operator.

² Or: 'is a partial referent of', 'is expressed on some precisification by', ...

507WilliamsonV says we find [instances of] UNBOUNDEDNESS appealing because, in general, ‘we are tempted to deny the truth of a proposition when we cannot conceive (even in broad outline) a way of coming to know its truth’. I think this may be a good explanation for some philosophers in the verificationist/Dummettian tradition, but the attribution of such quasi-verificationist thoughts to the “folk” seems a stretch.³

6 Explaining the speech behavior associated with vagueness

There’s another puzzle associated with vagueness, that’s only tangentially related to the Sorites. In a range of cases (‘borderline cases’), even well-informed speakers are averse to giving flat ‘yes’ and ‘no’ answers to a yes-no question. They prefer to *hedge*, often by offering more detail.⁴ *Question:* Why do we prefer to avoid just saying ‘yes’ or ‘no’ in such cases?

Basic pluralist answer: If we said ‘yes’ or ‘no’ (without lots of clarification), we would be asserting something something false, and we don’t want to do that.

Bonus: Pluralism also neatly explains another fact that some other accounts struggle with, namely that we are *also* averse to just saying ‘I don’t know’ in these cases (without further clarification). *Explanation:* saying ‘I don’t know’ would also involve asserting something false, since some of the propositions we were asked about are ones we *do* know (or know to be false).

Of course there are lots of other possible explanations of these familiar facts; trying to catalogue and compare them would take us too far afield. Instead I think it’s better to focus on an explanandum that’s harder for non-pluralists: the fact that even when speakers are constrained in such a way that saying ‘yes’ and saying ‘no’ (without followup) are the only options, different speakers break different ways, even when they are very well-informed and co-operative (motivated just by a desire to inform rather than mislead). Call this **forced-choice variability**.⁵

Forced-choice variability isn’t mysterious for the pluralist. Compatibly with being “co-operative”, different speakers can have different fine-grained preferences as between the deleterious consequences of saying ‘no’ and those of saying ‘yes’, even if there are no relevant differences in their beliefs.

But it’s mysterious if there only one proposition *p* expressed by the question. If they all know it’s the one expressed, shouldn’t the policy *say ‘yes’ if p and ‘no’ if not-p* be a natural “co-ordination equilibrium”, so

³ Also, there are many subject matters where we feel no Sorites-like puzzlement for which knowledge is possible, if it all, only for creatures with abilities vastly greater than ours. It’s very far from obvious that they are possible, so it’s not plausible that our lack of puzzlement arises from some sort of assumption that it is possible.

⁴ Are most philosophy professors writers? — Well, most of them write papers and books aimed at other philosophers, but only a few write for a general audience.
Is your brother bald? —He does have a pretty big bald spot.
Are you in a relationship? — It’s complicated.

⁵ It’s the basis of the argument in Williamson 1994: 199 that ‘we have no idea how to conceive borderline cases in such a way that nothing in them lies hidden from ordinary speakers’.

if the speakers are all relevantly well-informed, they would all follow it and thus all say the same thing?

“Epistemicist” response: There is a single proposition expressed (asserted, meant. . .), but no ordinary speakers, even well-informed ones, can know whether it’s true.

– This seems deeply implausible!

(i) In simple signalling systems (fruit exploration case), analogues of forced-choice variability can readily arise without relevant uncertainty; and the differences seem just a matter of degree.

(ii) In realistic cases of forced-choice variability, the differences between different co-operative speakers’ reactions are driven by differences of preference, not of credence—‘Have all the cups been washed?’

(iii) Epistemicism can’t explain why it’s often bad to answer ‘no’ to ‘Do you know whether *P*?’

(iv) The epistemicist explanation conflicts with the only workable monist response to Argument One (see last week’s handout). That response involves making the following speech when one is in a specialized context: ‘The property of being a cup is the one that ordinary indifferent uses of ‘cup’ express; it’s a property that glasses instantiate [/do not instantiate], and we are in a position to know that.’

Non-epistemicist, non-pluralist response: Although there is only one proposition expressed, *expressing* plays no special role in our preference systems. Speakers don’t *care* any more about avoiding sentences that *express* falsehoods than about avoiding sentences that bear any of many other one-one relations to falsehoods. So there is nothing to make ‘express a truth’ a co-ordination equilibrium.

– This is workable, so the argument isn’t a full success. However, it concedes pluralism in the case of relations like *caring about*.

References

- Unger, Peter (1980), ‘The Problem of the Many’, *Midwest Studies in Philosophy*, 5/1: 411–68.
 Williamson, Timothy (1994), *Vagueness* (London: Routledge).